

The first 90 days after a property lands in *your hands*.

A short field guide for families navigating an inherited property after a life transition.

Not a checklist for selling. A map for the months before the selling conversation happens, so the decisions you make hold up later. The three phases inside are the ones I have watched separate the families who land in a good place from the ones who carry regret about the property for years.

WHAT'S INSIDE

Three phases in the first 90 days. Four facts before any decision is final. Five paths worth comparing for any inherited property, in any market.

AN INHERITANCE IS RARELY JUST A HOUSE

The first three months *set the rest of the decision.*

A property usually arrives in your life through a moment you did not plan for. A parent passes. A grandparent moves into memory care. A divorce settles. A sibling steps back from a shared home. The keys land in your hands at the same time as everything else, and the pressure to do something with the property starts almost immediately. Wholesaler letters. A neighbor with an unsolicited offer over the fence. A cousin who has a strong opinion. A line item on the probate paperwork that uses the word value and sets a number in everyone's head before anyone has actually checked it.

The families who land in a good place rarely move quickly in the first 90 days, and they rarely freeze. They use that window to understand what they have actually inherited, including the parts that are not on the deed. The tax position. The legal status. The family alignment. The condition of the building. The market the property sits in. By the end of those 90 days, the path is usually clear, and the decision feels like one the family chose rather than one that got made on top of them.

This guide walks through what to do, and what to wait on, in each of the three phases. It is written for any inherited property in any market. The questions are the same. The math is the same. The order matters.

HOW TO USE THIS GUIDE

Read all three phases. Note the items that do not yet have an answer. Bring those to whoever you trust to help you decide, including the estate attorney and a CPA who has handled an inherited property before. Or bring them to a 30 minute strategy session. There is no commitment to list.

PHASE 01 · THE PAUSE

Do nothing *irreversible.*

The first two weeks are the most expensive ones to rush through, and the easiest ones to over-act in. Grief, logistics, and the sudden arrival of mail addressed to the deceased all push toward the same instinct, which is to do something. Most of the something is irreversible. A property emptied too quickly loses items that turn out to matter. A verbal yes to a neighbor or an investor anchors a number that becomes hard to move off. A cleaning company hired in the first week can throw away paperwork the estate needs.

The discipline in weeks one and two is the opposite of action. The job is to secure the building, gather the paperwork, and notify the right people, and that is it. No price conversations. No commitments to any path. No agreements with anyone who shows up unprompted. If a cash offer arrives in this window, the answer is a polite acknowledgment and a request for the offer in writing, filed away for later. Speed is not the strategy in the first two weeks.

What to do in this phase

- Gather the deed, the will or trust documents, recent tax bills, the insurance policy, mortgage statements, and utility accounts into one folder, physical or digital. The estate attorney can usually pull anything missing through standard requests.
- Secure the building. Change locks if appropriate. Notify the insurance carrier that the home is now vacant or occupied differently, which often changes the policy terms in ways that matter if something happens before the policy is updated. Keep utilities on for now, even if no one is living there, so the building does not deteriorate.
- Retain or confirm the estate attorney. Give your CPA a heads up that an inherited property is now part of the picture, even if there is nothing to file yet.
- Send a short note in writing to each heir saying that no decisions about the property are being made yet, and that there will be a conversation in the next 30 to 60 days once the basics are mapped. This one message prevents most of the family friction that shows up later.

WATCH OUT FOR

Anyone who shows up in the first two weeks asking for a commitment of any kind. Wholesalers, neighbors, family members with strong opinions, and well-meaning friends who have a contractor they trust. *Every commitment made in this window costs more to unwind than it would to wait.*

PHASE 02 · THE FACTS

Gather what you have *actually inherited.*

By week three the dust settles enough that the property can be looked at on its own terms, not as a piece of the grief. This is the phase where the inheritance becomes something specific instead of something heavy. There are four facts to gather, and the order matters less than the discipline of getting all four before the conversation about selling begins.

01 · The legal status

What stage is the estate in, and what is the executor or trustee actually allowed to sign right now? Is the property in probate, out of probate, held in a trust, held jointly, or held by multiple heirs with different interests? Each of these is a different timeline and a different set of moves available. The estate attorney maps this in a short conversation.

02 · The tax position

The most important number nobody mentions in the first weeks is the step-up in basis. The property's tax basis usually resets to the value at the date of death rather than what the original owner paid. A home bought decades ago for one number and inherited at a much higher number has a basis that can dramatically reduce or eliminate the capital gains tax on a sale, but only if it is documented and used inside the window where it applies. The CPA conversation belongs in week three or four, not after a sale is already in motion.

03 · The family alignment

The conversation about the property is also a conversation about the family. Each heir has a different financial position, a different emotional connection, and often a different opinion about what should happen. The decisions that hold up over time are the ones where every heir has been heard before the path gets chosen. The conversation is uncomfortable. It is also the work.

04 · The condition

A clear picture of the systems, the major components, the deferred maintenance, the contents still to sort, and the realistic buyer pool for the property as it sits today. A walkthrough with someone who looks at homes for a living is worth more than three opinions from family members who have not been inside in years.

WATCH OUT FOR

Anyone who quotes a price for the property before the legal status, the tax position, and the condition have all been mapped. *A price quote without those three pieces is a guess at best and a sales tactic at worst.*

PHASE 03 · THE PATH

Map the options *that actually fit.*

By the start of week seven you have the facts. The legal status is clear. The tax position is mapped. The family has had at least one real conversation. The condition is understood. This is the phase where the path gets chosen. There are usually five paths worth considering, and the right one is the one that fits the answers from the first six weeks.

Open market sale

The property gets prepped, listed, and sold to a retail buyer through the standard process. Best fit when the property is in solid condition, the family is aligned on timing, the estate is clear to sell, and the local market rewards the type of buyer that pays the most.

Cash investor sale

The property gets sold off market to an investor for a faster timeline and an as-is closing. Best fit when speed and certainty are worth real money to the family, when the property needs work the family does not want to manage, or when an investor in this specific market pays close to retail for as-is condition. The honest version runs the cash math against the open market math, with both sets of numbers in front of the family at the same time.

Targeted improvements, then list

Specific spends on the items that produce a return, then an open market sale. Best fit when a small, defined investment unlocks a meaningfully larger sale price and the family has the bandwidth to manage the work. The discipline is that every line item on the improvement list has a number next to it, not a vibe.

Heir buyout

One heir buys the property from the others at an agreed price. Best fit when one family member has both the emotional connection to keep the home and the financial position to make the others whole. The basis math matters here, because the buyout price affects what the keeper's future sale looks like for tax purposes.

Short hold and rent

The property gets rented for a defined window before any sale decision. Best fit when the market is in a moment where waiting is likely to add real value, when the family wants more time, or when the tax picture meaningfully changes inside the hold window. Rarely the right path if no one has run the landlord math, but for the right family it is sometimes the best answer on the table.

WATCH OUT FOR

Any conversation about the path that starts before the four facts in Phase Two are mapped. *The right path is the one that fits the answers.* Without the answers, the path is a guess that the family pays for later.

READY WHEN YOU ARE

Want to walk through this *for your family's situation?*

These three phases are not the only way to navigate the first 90 days, but they are the rhythm I have watched separate the families who land in a good place from the ones who carry regret about the property for years. The discipline is mostly about order. The pause first. The facts second. The path third. Almost every expensive mistake I have seen in an inherited property starts with those three phases happening out of order, or with one of them skipped entirely.

If you want to walk through them on your specific situation with me, that is what a strategy session is for. We map where you are in the 90 days, what is already in place, what is missing, and what the path looks like from here. There is no commitment to list. Most of the value is in the conversation itself.

BOOK A STRATEGY SESSION

A 30 minute call to walk the property through the *three phases together*.

Book a strategy call

calendly.com/kristarecker/free-30-minute-strategy-call